

KITCHEN THREE

METHOD CREATES DISTINCTION

GUIDE 03 · COMPLIANCE

HACCP *Made Simple*

A practical, plain-language guide for small food businesses in Egypt — what HACCP actually is, what the NFSA expects, and the minimum viable system that keeps you compliant without drowning in paperwork.

INTRODUCTION

What this guide *is* — and what it isn't.

HACCP is not a stack of binders. It's a way of thinking about your food, your kitchen, and the seven places things go wrong. Done right, it's the cheapest insurance policy a food business will ever buy.

If you operate a kitchen in Egypt — a café, cloud kitchen, catering operation, central production unit, school cafeteria, or bakery — sooner or later HACCP becomes a question of when, not if. The NFSA (National Food Safety Authority) has been steadily formalising requirements. Corporate clients increasingly demand certified suppliers. Foreign investors won't sign a partnership without it.

This guide is built for the operator who has read three articles online and is now more confused than when they started. We strip HACCP down to what it actually is, what regulators in Egypt actually check for, and the minimum documentation that keeps you covered.

It is **not** a certification document. Certification is performed by accredited third parties. What we'll give you is a clean mental model and a checklist — so when you do engage with certification, you walk in with a system, not a question.

WHO THIS IS FOR

Small to mid-size food operations in Egypt with 1 to 30 staff. If you produce, prepare, store, or serve food — this applies to you. If you only resell sealed packaged goods, your obligations are narrower (handle this as basic food-safety hygiene rather than full HACCP).

The seven HACCP principles, *in plain Egyptian*.

HACCP has seven formal principles defined by the Codex Alimentarius. Memorise them as a checklist, not as theory.

1

HAZARD ANALYSIS

For every dish, ingredient, and step, ask: what could harm a customer? Three categories — **biological** (bacteria, viruses, parasites), **chemical** (cleaning residue, allergens, pesticide), **physical** (glass, hair, metal, bone). Write down what you find. This is the foundation.

2

CRITICAL CONTROL POINTS (CCPS)

Where in the process can a hazard actually be controlled or eliminated? Typical CCPs in Egyptian kitchens: cooking temperature, cold storage, allergen segregation, supplier raw-material reception, hot-holding. Most kitchens have 3 to 6 real CCPs — not 25.

3

CRITICAL LIMITS

Each CCP gets a measurable boundary. Chicken core temp $\geq 74^{\circ}\text{C}$ for 15 seconds. Cold storage $\leq 4^{\circ}\text{C}$. Hot hold $\geq 63^{\circ}\text{C}$. Specific numbers. No "thoroughly cooked." Limits are auditable; opinions are not.

4

MONITORING

Who measures what, when, and with what tool. A digital probe thermometer at every station. Cold-room temp logged twice a day. Allergen swabs after deep-clean. This is where 90% of small operators fail audit — not because they don't do it, but because they don't record it.

5

CORRECTIVE ACTION

If a CCP fails — what do you do? Reject the batch? Reheat? Recook? Discard? Each CCP needs a pre-decided response written down. Audit teams ask: "show me a deviation log." Have one.

6

VERIFICATION

Periodic checks that the system works. Internal audits monthly, swab tests quarterly, third-party audit annually. Verification is what separates a HACCP plan from a HACCP practice.

7

RECORD KEEPING

If it isn't written, it didn't happen. Temperature logs, supplier certificates, training records, deviation reports, cleaning checklists. Six categories of records. Keep them for two years minimum.

Prerequisite programs — where the *real work* lives.

Before HACCP can do anything for you, your kitchen needs a working foundation. These are the prerequisite programs (PRPs), and they are 80% of the actual workload of getting certified.

a. Good Manufacturing Practice (GMP)

- ☐ Facility layout designed for one-way flow — raw in, cooked out, no crossover
- ☐ Smooth, washable, light-colored surfaces in food zones (no porous wood, no peeling paint)
- ☐ Separate handwash sinks (food prep and toilets do not share)
- ☐ Pest control contract with licensed provider, monthly visits, written reports
- ☐ Staff uniforms, hair covers, beard nets — issued and replaced

b. Sanitation Standard Operating Procedures (SSOPs)

- ☐ Daily cleaning schedule by zone — assigned, signed, dated
- ☐ Cleaning chemicals stored separately from food, locked when possible
- ☐ Concentration / dilution chart posted at every chemical use point
- ☐ Cleaning verification — visual + ATP swab quarterly minimum
- ☐ Deep clean schedule (weekly, monthly, quarterly) — written and audited

c. Supplier Approval

- ☐ Written supplier list with category, license number, last audit date
- ☐ Specifications for each material — receiving criteria, rejection conditions
- ☐ Annual supplier audit (visit, paperwork review, or third-party report)
- ☐ Certificate of analysis (COA) for high-risk inputs — dairy, meat, ready-to-eat

d. Staff Training

- ☐ Food handler training certificate for every kitchen staff member
- ☐ Annual refresher with attendance log

- ☐ New-hire induction within first 7 days — documented
- ☐ Health screening on hire, annual stool test for food handlers (Egyptian regulation)

THE HONEST TRUTH

If your prerequisite programs are solid, HACCP becomes a 2-week project on top. If they aren't, HACCP becomes a 6-month rebuild. Spend the time on prerequisites first.

The Egyptian regulatory *landscape*.

Which agencies care, what they actually check, and where Egyptian practice differs from international guidance.

The bodies that matter

BODY	WHAT THEY REGULATE
NFSA	National Food Safety Authority — the lead food regulator since 2017. Licensing of food facilities, import inspection, recalls.
EOS	Egyptian Organization for Standardization — sets technical specifications and standards (ES specifications) referenced in NFSA enforcement.
Ministry of Health	Food handler health certificates, kitchen hygiene inspection at governorate level. Still active in food handler licensing.
Egyptian Accreditation Council (EGAC)	Accredits the certification bodies that audit your HACCP. You hire one of these to certify you.

Documents you will actually be asked for

- ☐ NFSA establishment licence (for production / preparation kitchens)
- ☐ Food handler health certificates — every staff member, current
- ☐ HACCP plan in Arabic and English (Arabic is non-negotiable for NFSA inspections)
- ☐ Temperature monitoring logs — last 30 days minimum on-site
- ☐ Supplier list with copies of supplier licences
- ☐ Pest control reports — last 12 months
- ☐ Training records — last 12 months
- ☐ Internal audit report — at least one in last 12 months

A COMMON TRAP

HACCP and ISO 22000 are not the same thing. Many Egyptian operators confuse them. HACCP is the methodology; ISO 22000 is a full Food Safety Management System that includes HACCP as one component. For a small business, certified HACCP is usually enough. ISO 22000 is a step up that adds management-system requirements — pursue only when corporate or export clients demand it.

Your *90-day* path to certification.

Most small operations can reach certified-and-audited inside 90 days, in three phases.

Days 1–30. Foundation

- ☐ Map your full process — every step from delivery to plate
- ☐ Walk the facility with a fresh eye and a clipboard — list every GMP gap
- ☐ Buy or upgrade: probe thermometers, fridge thermometers, hand sanitiser stations, log clipboards, colour-coded chopping boards
- ☐ Repaint, reseal, refloor any food zones that aren't smooth and washable
- ☐ Set up your supplier file — written specs, request licences

Days 31–60. Documentation

- ☐ Write the HACCP plan — flowcharts, hazard analyses, CCPs, critical limits
- ☐ Write SOPs for every CCP — who, what, when, how, what if
- ☐ Build the log book set — receiving, cooking, cooling, hot-hold, cold storage, cleaning, deviation
- ☐ Train the team — full course for kitchen leads, briefer module for all staff
- ☐ Translate everything into Arabic — NFSA inspectors operate in Arabic

Days 61–90. Practice and Audit

- ☐ Run the system live for at least 30 days — fill the logs daily
- ☐ Conduct an internal audit — find what fails before the auditor does
- ☐ Fix the gaps the internal audit finds
- ☐ Engage an EGAC-accredited certification body for the external audit
- ☐ External audit — Stage 1 (paperwork), Stage 2 (on-site). Pass both.

The kitchens that pass on the first attempt are not the ones with the prettiest binders. They are the ones where the cook can tell you, on day forty-seven, exactly where the temperature log is and what to do if a fridge goes above 4°C.

— KITCHEN THREE FIELD NOTE

Five mistakes that *fail audits*.

The patterns we see again and again. Avoid these five and you remove the most common failure modes.

1. Missing logs for 'just a few days'

Auditors look at recent logs first. A two-week gap in the cold-storage temperature log isn't a paperwork issue — it's evidence the system isn't running. Treat the log as part of the cooking. Not optional. Not later.

2. Generic HACCP plan copied from another kitchen

A plan that mentions equipment you don't own, hazards that don't apply, or CCPs that don't exist in your menu is worse than no plan. Auditors spot it inside ten minutes. Write yours from your menu, your flow, your kitchen.

3. Cleaning chemicals stored next to ingredients

The single most common visual finding in Egyptian kitchen audits. Even one bottle of degreaser on the dry-store shelf is a critical non-conformity. Separate, labelled, locked when possible.

4. No supplier paperwork

"They've delivered us tomatoes for ten years" is not supplier approval. You need their commercial register, NFSA licence, and a basic specification of what you receive. Build the file before the audit.

5. Staff who don't know their CCPs

The auditor will ask your line cook: "what temperature do you cook chicken to?" If the answer is a shrug, your training program failed. Print laminated CCP cards. Post them at the station.

WHERE TO GO NEXT

The honest next step depends on where you are. If you have a kitchen but no HACCP, start with a one-day diagnostic. If you have a plan but no certification, start with an internal audit. If you have certification but it expires soon, start with a re-readiness review. Kitchen Three runs all three formats.

Ready to *build*?

Kitchen Three runs Kitchen Hive — a HACCP-certified, Codex Alimentarius-compliant cloud kitchen facility in New Cairo. We help operators of every size get from kitchen-as-it-is to certified — usually inside 90 days. Talk to us about an audit, a setup, or full certification support.

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